

Alabama Learning Hour

Introduce Yourself! Patient Verbs and Location

March 24th, 2026

1 *Amoklaha* Text

Amoklaha

My Friends

Ava: Chaholchifaya Ava. Chiholchifak naasolin?

Jacob: Chaholchifaya Jacob.

Ava: Chikaanõ?

Jacob: Chakaanobi. Isnã?

Ava: Chakaanobi. Achayokpo.

Tanya: Hachikaano. Chaholchifaya Tanya. Hachiholchifaya naasolĩ?

Ava: Poholchifaya Ava, Jacob.

Tanya: Hachikaanõ?

Ava: Pokaanobi. Apoyokpo.

My Friends - English Translation

Ava: My name is Ava. What is your name?

Jacob: Chaholchifaya Jacob.

Ava: How are you?

Jacob: I am good. You?

Ava: I am good. I'm happy.

Tanya: Hello y'all. My name is Tanya. What are y'all's names?

Ava: Our names are Ava and Jacob.

Tanya: How are y'all?

Ava: We are good. We are happy.

2 Vocabulary

Verbs

holchifa	to be named
kaano	to be good
ayokpa	to be happy

Last week we learned the followign recipe to possess certain nouns.

Possessives I Easy Recipe

[**Possessor** + **Noun**]

Possessor Morphemes:

	Singular	Plural	
1	cha- ‘my’	ko-/po- ‘our’	<i>1st person = speaker</i>
2	chi- ‘your’	hachi- ‘y’ all’s’	<i>2nd person = addresse</i>
3	noun (e.g. Ava)	noun (e.g. children)	<i>3rd person = someone else</i>

- Put the Possessor to the left of the noun. If the possessor is ‘my’, ‘you’, ‘our’, or ‘y’alls”, it will become one word with the noun!
- Some families prefer to use *ko-* for ‘our’, some prefer *po-*. Choose whichever one you like (*or ask a family elder for a suggestion*)!

- (1)
- cha-** + **holchifa** = *chaholchifa* ‘my name’
 - chi-** + **holchifa** = *chiholchifa* ‘your name’
 - Ava** + **holchifa** = *Ava holchifa* ‘Ava’s name’
 - ko-/po** + **holchifa** = *koholchifa* or *poholchifa* ‘our name’
 - hachi-** + **holchifa** = *hachiholchifa* ‘your name’
 - poskoha** + **holchifa** = *poskoha holchifa* ‘children’s name’

- (2)
- my arm (*cha-sakba*)
 - your wife (*chi-halki*)
 - our barber (*ko-hissi koloffi*)

However, we can also add these markers to **patient** verbs.

3 Patient Verbs

- In the past couple of weeks we have learned how to talk about ourselves if we are the **agent** in a sentence.
- For example: Anok bitli-**li**-ti
- But there are also verbs that have one argument, but it's a *Patient*!

(3) Patient Verbs

are verbs that take 1 argument, and it is a Patient

Examples of Alabama Patient Verbs

Verb	Translation	Verb	Translation
tammi	fall	nokłikiicha	be afraid
kaano	be good	falanka	be awake
sooka	be held	(i)stonafayli	faint, pass out
palki	be fast	chaaha	be tall

- With all of these verbs, the argument is a passive undergoer of the situation described by the verb—the action/event/situation just happens to them, *they don't have a say!*

Patient Verb Sentence Easy Recipe (Past, Statement)

- (4) [Patient + k] [Patient + Verb + Tense]
 [ano + k] [cha- + tammi + ti]
 I my fall past
Meaning: 'I fell.'

★ **CAREFUL!** If a verb begins with a vowel, the patient morpheme will do something special:

- Words beginning with **i-** will delete the i!
ibiihomma 'to blush' → *cha-bii-homma-hchi* 'I'm blushing'
- Words beginning with **a-** or **o-** will delete their first vowel, and put an **a-** before the patient marker.
ayokpa 'to be happy' → *a-cha-yokp-o* 'I'm happy'

Patient Morphemes:

	Singular	Plural	
1	cha- 'my'	ko-/po- 'our'	<i>1st person = speaker</i>
2	chi- 'your'	hachi- 'y'all's'	<i>2nd person = addressee</i>
3		(ho-)	<i>3rd person = someone else</i>

Let's practice! *How would you say this in Alabama?*

palki 'to be fast'

- (5) a. I was fast.
 b. You were fast.
 c. Ava was fast.
 d. We were fast.
 e. Y'all were fast.
 f. The children (*poskoha*)
 were fast.

sooka 'to be held'

- (6) a. I was held.
 b. You were held.
 c. Ava was held.
 d. We were held.
 e. Y'all were held.
 f. The children (*poskoha*)
 were held.

kaano 'to be good'

- (7) a. I was good.

- b. You were good.
 c. Ava was good.

- d. We were good. (8)
 e. Y'all were good.
 f. The children (*poskoha*)
 were good.

- a. I was tall.
 b. You were tall.
 c. Ava was tall.
 d. We were tall.
 e. Y'all were tall.
 f. The children (*poskoha*)
 were tall.

chaaha 'to be tall'

Grammar Practice: How are you?

- **Let's Practice!** With a partner, talk about how someone is feeling. Replace Ex1 with the verb on the left, and Ex2 with the verb on the right.

- New Words: Mahmin — but maakayaalon — now,
 piyaaka — yesterday

A: Chifoni kaanō?

A: How is your sister?

B: Kaanobi/Kankobi.

Piyaakon [Ex1: ɬakcha]-ti, mahmin maakayaalon, [Ex2: ayokp]o.

B: Good/Not good. She was sad yesterday, but now, she is happy.

A: Mahmin, chikaanō? [Ex2: achiyokpa]?

A: But, how are you? Are you [Ex2: happy]?

B: Ay, [Achayokpa]-hcholo.

B: Yes, I'm happy.

1. Example: (1) ɬakcha — lonely, (2) ayokpa — happy
2. kaano — good, hoopa — sick
3. nochihla — sleepy, falanka — awake
4. kaano — good, maɬatli — scared
5. nokhammi — angry, ayokpa — happy

4 Talking about location: *Where is Ava walking?*

- Now that you know how to ask basic questions, you can practice asking people more complicated questions; for example, “What are you doing?” “Where are you going?”
- Questions that use words like *what*, *when*, *where*, *why* are called *wh*-questions in English. Alabama has these too, but they don’t usually start with *wh*!
- Today we will learn one of these words: ‘where?’ — **naksifon**

Asking ‘Where questions’ Easy Recipe

Option 1: [**naksifon** + (**Agent-k**) + **Verb** + **Tense**]

- (9) a. naksifon + Ava-k + chiyahli + hchĩ
where Ava walk ing?
naksifon Avak chiyahlihchĩ?
‘Where is Ava walking?’
- b. naksifon + bitli + hchĩ
where dance ing?
naksifon bitlihchĩ?
‘Where is (Ava) dancing?’

Option 2: [(**Agent-k**) + **naksifon** + **Verb** + **Tense**]

- (10) a. Ava-k + naksifon + chiyahli + hchĩ
Ava where walk ing?
Avak naksifon chiyahlihchĩ?
‘Where is Ava walking?’
- b. naksifon + chiyahli + hchĩ
where walk ed?
naksifon chiyahlihchĩ?
‘Where is (Ava) walking?’

✧ Sometimes, people say **nakson** instead of **naksifon**. This is also correct, but is ambiguous (*Nakson* also means ‘who?’!) so we use *naksifon*.

- In English, when we want to answer these kind of questions, you can use the preposition *to*.

(11) I am going to the store.

- Alabama doesn't have prepositions like English does. But it does have a special **locative marker** that tells us where something happened at, where someone is going to, or where someone is coming from.

(12) anok ischoopasi-fon bitli-li-hchi.
 I store-to dancing-I-ing
 I am dancing at/in/by the store

(13) anok ischoopasi-fon aḥḥa-li-hchi.
 I store-to go-I-ing
 I am going to the store

There are special pieces we can add after the noun if we want to specify the location of something, but these aren't needed!

- | | |
|--------------------------|----------------------------|
| • hayo 'inside' | • paana 'on top of' |
| • acha 'outside' | • nota 'below' |
| • taḥḥa 'side of' | • ayakha 'close to' |

Answering ‘where questions’ Easy Recipe: Generic location

[Agent-k + Place + -fon + Verb]

- (14) a. Avak + ischoopasi + -fon + bitlihchi =
Ava store at/to/from is.dancing =
Avak ischoopasifon bitlihchi.
‘Ava is dancing at the store.’
- b. Avak + abohli + -fon + chiyahlihchi =
Ava forest at/to/from is.walking =
Avak abohlifon chiyalihchi.
‘Ava is walking in the forest.’
- c. Avak + Dalaska + -fon + aHahchi =
Ava Dallas at/to/from is.going =
Avak Dalaskafon aHahchi.
‘Ava is going to Dallas.’

Answering ‘where questions’ Easy Recipe: Specific location

[Agent-k + Place + hayo/acha/talla/etc.- + -n + Verb]

✧ **Careful!** Often, we replace the last vowel of these special location describing words with **-o!**

- (15) a. **Avak** + **ischoopasi** + **hayo-** + -n + **bitlihchi** =
Ava store inside at is.dancing =
Avak ischoopasi hayon bitlihchi.
‘Ava is dancing inside the store.’
- b. **Avak** + **holihta** + **ach-** + -on + **chiyahlihchi** =
Ava fence outside at is.walking =
Avak holihta achon chiyalihchi.
‘Ava is walking outside the fence.’
- c. **Avak** + **iisa** + **paan-** + -on + **hompanihchi** =
Ava house on.top at is.playing =
Avak iisa paanon hompanihchi.
‘Ava is swimming on top of the house.’

Example Location words

- **iisa** ‘home/house’
- **okichoba** ‘lake’
- **bokkochaaha** ‘mountain’
- **ayahchihka** ‘garden’
- **ischoopasi** ‘store’
- **Dalaska** ‘Dallas’
- **abohli** ‘forest’
- **ischoba** ‘church’
- **Yosti/Houstonka** ‘Houston’

Let's Practice! *Pick a verb, and ask where your partner is doing something. Then answer where you are doing it!*

- (16) a. Person 1: naksifon chimoklak bitli-hchĩ?
Where is your friend dancing?
Where is your friend(=chimokla) dancing?
b. Person 2: iisa-fon (amoklak) bitli-hchi.
house-at (I) dance-I-ing
My friend is dancing home.
- (17) chokkooli (one person) - to sit a. Where is Jackson dancing?
a. Where is Ava sitting? b. Jackson is dancing
b. Ava is sitting _____. _____.
- (18) hachaali (one person) - to stand (21) hinakahli - to wait
a. Where is Tanya standing? a. Where is the cow(=waaka) waiting?
b. Tanya is standing b. The cow is waiting
_____. _____.
- (19) chiyahli - to walk (22) choffi - to jump
a. Where is Jacob walking? a. Where is the rabbit(=chokfi) jumping?
b. Jacob is walking b. The rabbit is jumping
_____. _____.
- (20) bitli - to dance

(23) ilakomayli - to swim

a. Where is the fish(=łalo)
swimming?

b. The fish is swimming
_____.